

Flush Without Fear: Before You Sign With Brand Ranker

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Short version: don't sign with Brand Ranker yet. Both companies by that name measure AI visibility, and neither one does the work that gets a plumber more calls. Your reviews already beat most of the competition. What's holding you back is a few fixable basics:

1. **Fix your Google Business Profile.** Set your real hours (the site says 24/7, the listings don't), hide your street address if it's your home, add services and photos. This is the biggest lever for both the map pack and AI answers.
2. **Get on the lists AI reads.** Yelp now feeds ChatGPT directly. Add Tacoma's "best plumber" lists (Expertise.com, ThreeBestRated), BBB and Angi.
3. **Clean up the website.** Put the city and service in the homepage title, retire the duplicate .net site, and make each city page genuinely local.

Do those first, and spend on Local Services Ads before you spend on any AI SEO tool.

Where you stand today

Your reviews are excellent, and your search setup isn't making the most of them. Checked from the outside on Sept 28, 2026, without access to your Google or Search Console accounts.

Working for you

- A 5.0 Google rating. Review sites show anywhere from 79 to 109 reviews, so check the real number in your profile.
- Nextdoor Neighborhood Favorite, 2022 through 2025.
- A clear offer: 24/7 service, no after-hours charge, and "It Flows or It's Free."
- Big call and booking buttons on the site, with coupons running.
- 11 city pages already built for your service area.

Costing you calls

Issue	Why it matters	Fix
Searches for "plumber Graham WA" and "best plumber in Graham WA" didn't show you, even though Graham is your home base	This is the search that pays. Roto-Rooter, Graham Plumbing Pros, Newton Family and others show up instead.	GBP work plus reviews (the plan below)
The homepage title and H1 name no city or service ("Fearless Plumbers in South Puget Sound" / "Emergency Plumbers")	Google has less to go on when it matches you to local searches	Something like "Plumber in Graham & Puyallup, WA — 24/7, No After-Hours Fee"
A second site, flushwithoutfear.net, repeats your business info	Two sites can split your credibility and confuse Google	Redirect .net to .com, page by page
At least one city page in Google's index (/plumbing-spanaway/) returns a 404 error	Google shows a dead page, and whoever clicks it leaves	Redirect it to the working Spanaway page
Review sites list you as Mon-Fri 8-8 and Sat 8-1, but the site says 24/7	Google shows you as closed at night, which is exactly when emergency calls come in, and "open now" affects ranking	If you really answer 24/7, set 24-hour hours on your Google profile
Your street address in Graham shows on several listings	If it's your home, Google's rules for service-area businesses say to hide it. Leaving it up risks a profile suspension.	Hide the address in your profile and list service areas
You're not on the Tacoma "best plumber" lists (Expertise.com, ThreeBestRated) or on BBB, Angi or HomeAdvisor	AI answers pull from exactly these lists and directories	Apply to the lists, and claim the directory listings

One honest caveat: I checked search results through a research tool, not a live Google Maps search from Graham. Search "plumber near me" from your phone at home to confirm.

What Brand Ranker is actually selling

Two companies use the name, and neither one gets a plumber ranked. Both measure AI visibility. Neither does the work.

Company	What it is	Price	Fit for a plumber
BrandRanker AI (brandranker.ai)	A one-time scan that grades your site across 20+ "AI visibility drivers." Its own FAQ says: "BrandRanker focuses on measurement, not implementation."	\$79, one time	A cheap report card, and free tools already cover most of it. No named owner, address or legal entity on the site.
BrandRank.AI, Inc. (Cincinnati)	Enterprise software that tracks how ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude and Perplexity talk about big brands	Not published; built for Fortune 500 marketing teams	Wrong tool. Real company (BBB A rating), wrong customer.

If someone is pitching you a monthly "Brand Ranker" program, it's probably a reseller or agency using one of these reports as the hook. Before anything else, get the exact company name and website.

Red flags to watch for in any AI SEO pitch:

- **A visibility score or letter grade as the headline result.** These measure whether an AI mentions you, not whether your phone rings. Nobody has published evidence that ties them to booked jobs.
- **"We'll get you recommended by ChatGPT."** Across ~350,000 business locations, ChatGPT recommended only 1.2%. Google's map pack showed 35.9% ([SOCi study](#)). Nobody can promise that spot.
- **Ilms.txt files, special "AI schema," or rewriting pages "for AI."** Google's own AI guidance lists these as unnecessary ([Google](#)).
- **Mass-produced city pages or blog posts.** Google treats these as scaled content abuse and doorway pages. They usually just get filtered out quietly, with no warning.
- **Bought mentions, press-release blasts or review programs with incentives.** Google filters fake mentions, and it now penalizes undisclosed incentivized reviews.

What actually drives calls for a local plumber in 2026

Most of what gets you into AI answers is the same thing that gets you into the Google map pack. It isn't a separate project.

- **Your Google Business Profile is the biggest single lever.** A 2026 survey of local search experts weighted it at about 32% of map-pack ranking, with reviews next at about 20% ([Whitespark](#)).
- **The top map-pack factors:** primary category, how close you are to the searcher, keywords in your business name, an address in the city being searched, and being open at the time of the search. That last one is why your listed hours matter.
- **AI answers lean on third-party proof.** The strongest factors for showing up in AI answers are expert "best of" lists, dedicated service pages, and review sites. In a 75,000-brand study, YouTube mentions and brand mentions around the web counted 2-3 times more than backlinks ([Ahrefs](#)).
- **Yelp now feeds ChatGPT.** OpenAI licensed Yelp's reviews and business data in July 2026, and Yelp appears on about 96% of ChatGPT's business cards ([Search Engine Land](#)). A strong Yelp profile is probably the best ChatGPT play there is.
- **Calls from organic listings are shrinking on mobile.** Google's new AI local results show 1-2 businesses instead of 3, often without a call button. Local Services Ads (the "Google Guaranteed" badge) keep their call button. Heads-up: starting Oct 1, 2026, Google charges for missed calls on LSAs, so answering every one counts more than ever.
- **Google's reviews rules tightened in 2026.** No review quotas for staff, and don't ask customers to name the tech in their review. Ask every customer the same simple way, with no reward attached.

A 90-day plan, in priority order

Most of this costs time rather than money. Each step also helps with AI answers.

Weeks 1-2: fix the foundation (about 5 hours)

- ☐ Google profile: set the real hours (24-hour if you truly answer), hide the address if it's your home, and list your service areas. Primary category Plumber, then add Drainage Service, Water Heater Installation, Emergency Plumber, and similar.
- ☐ Add a service to the profile for every job type you do, each with a sentence or two and a price range where you can.

- ☐ Upload 20+ real photos: vans, the crew, before-and-after shots, water heater installs. Then add a few every week.
- ☐ Redirect flushwithoutfear.net to .com, and fix the Spanaway 404.
- ☐ Rewrite the homepage title and H1 to name the service and your core cities.
- ☐ Set up free measurement: Google Search Console (its Generative AI report shows when you appear in AI results), Bing Webmaster Tools (it shows Copilot citations), and a separate call-tracking number on the Google profile, so you can see which calls it brings in.

Weeks 2-6: reviews and the places AI reads

- ☐ Send every customer a review link right after the job, by text, the same way every time. The number matters, and so does getting reviews steadily every week.
- ☐ Claim and fill out Yelp completely: photos, services, hours and service area. Reply to every review there as well.
- ☐ Claim BBB, Angi and HomeAdvisor. Put your license number on every listing and in the website footer.
- ☐ Submit to Expertise.com and ThreeBestRated for Tacoma. Both take applications, and a 5.0 rating with 100 reviews makes you a strong candidate.

Weeks 4-12: pages that earn the rank

- ☐ Give each main service its own real page: water heaters, repiping, drain cleaning, water lines, emergency. Show real jobs, real photos and what the work costs.
- ☐ Make every city page actually about that city: jobs you've done there, neighborhoods, local problems (old galvanized pipe, well water, septic). Test: delete the city name, and if the page could be about any town, rewrite it.
- ☐ Film short phone videos of real jobs and post them to YouTube and your Google profile. YouTube mentions are the strongest AI-visibility signal Ahrefs measured.
- ☐ Ask supply houses, builders, realtors you work with, and local news or community pages for a mention or a link.

Consider Local Services Ads. Plumbing qualifies. You pay per lead, not per click, and you keep a call button at the top of the page. It works best once reviews and hours are in order, since Google uses both to rank LSAs.

If you still want to hire someone

Hire a local SEO specialist who works with trades and reports in calls and booked jobs. Skip anyone who reports an "AI visibility score."

Ask before signing:

1. What's your exact company name and website, and who does the work?
2. Is this a report or a service? List the specific things you'll do each month.
3. Show me a home-services client whose calls or booked jobs went up. Mention counts don't count.
4. Will you publish content, build links or ask for reviews in my name? Show me examples first.
5. Who owns the website, the Google profile and the accounts if we part ways?

Contract terms to insist on:

- Month-to-month, or 90 days at most. No 6- or 12-month lock-in.
- You stay the owner of your Google profile and all your accounts. They get manager access only.
- A monthly report with calls, form leads, and map rank for "plumber" searches in your core cities.
- No automated city pages or blog posts published without your OK.

Free second opinions before paying anyone: the checklist above, plus Google Search Console and Bing Webmaster Tools. They cover most of what a \$79 audit would.

Sources

- [BrandRanker AI](#) · [BrandRank.AI](#) · [BrandRank.AI on BBB](#)
- [Flush Without Fear website](#) · [.net site](#) · [Nextdoor](#) · [Birdeye](#) · [BestProsInTown](#)
- [Whitespark Local Search Ranking Factors](#)
- [Google: AI optimization guidance](#)
- [SOCi AI local visibility report](#)
- [Ahrefs: what correlates with AI brand visibility](#)
- [OpenAI-Yelp deal](#)